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left their homes every day to keep hospitals running in the depths of Covid-19. The service business is our jewel; it is a recurring business. We cut all discretionary expenses, stopped travel, took pay cuts, etc., so that we could make a commitment to our customers and colleagues that we were going to get through this. We did not lay off a single colleague during Covid-19 and that built trust. Our factories remained open. We didn't miss a shipment, nor a delivery, even when semiconductors were hardly available.

Q: How did you get back on the growth track?

A: In late 2020, we were really struggling when doing our business reviews. I told the teams that we should be ready to accelerate. They were stunned, but my belief was that the market would come back.

When things started to look up, we hit the ground

“India is digitally native and that’s different... it gives us a unique ability to use that digital technology”

running and executed almost to perfection. The results speak for themselves—double-digit earnings per share growth, top line taking off and the confidence was back.

Q: You speak of a large organisation where decision-making takes time. In your current position, how or what do you tell your people, so that they think like entrepreneurs?

A: I can't think of too many companies where 34,000 mechanics and 7,000 installers are on their own every

day. They are independent representatives and solving customers' problems every day. That to me is entrepreneurial. We have 1,400 branch offices and each has a profit & loss. We tell people this when we go to recruit—join us in sales, learn our business and as you move up, there is an opportunity to run one of our branches.

Q: It's an incredible time across the globe. Don't you think Europe is in a challenging situation?

A: I'm not an economist. All I can share is our business is doing well. The indicators we're seeing in Europe are strong. Southern Europe—Spain and Italy—are very strong for us. The Middle-east... is back with a vengeance. It is true northern Europe has some challenges as does eastern Europe because of the [Ukraine] conflict.

We were preparing for a recession last summer and thought energy prices would spike with inflation continuing to grow. In reality, we were up in the mid-teens in terms of orders last year, plus there is a strong backlog in Europe, which will get us through this year. Next year, construction will still be alive.

There's a lot of potential in the emerging markets. You look at India, and there's probably no country I'm more optimistic about. The urbanisation rates are in the mid-30s. Our team has strong orders and we're the No. 1 player. We are pleased about every segment—residential or office or commercial—and that's why we've invested here. In 1996, we opened our factory in Bengaluru and we are really proud to say that, of everything we deliver in India, 95 per cent comes from our factory. So, we are fully in on “Made in India”. As a matter of fact, a few years ago, we moved our commercial and public escalator lines here so that we could support infrastructure and retail growth. India, for me, is a country that has been on the precipice of growth. It's your turn, and I wouldn't compare it to any other country. It's the right time with a country that is now leapfrogging so many others in terms